MADAM PRIME MINISTER

Fatima Sana Shaikh plays Indira Gandhi in the Meghna Gulzar-directed *Sam Bahadur*, based on the life of Field Marshal Sam Manekshaw



Q. How challenging was it to play Indira Gandhi, considering you are in your early thirties?

It was tough because it's a responsibility to play such a huge personality. Fortunately, Meghna Gulzar had a clear idea of what she wanted. She was certain about not using prosthetics. More than the physical aspects, she wanted me to capture the spirit of Indira Gandhi.

Q. Are we now more accepting of women-centric films?

Today, content rules and it doesn't matter whether it is a man or woman leading the film. The gap is narrowing as can be seen by the success of films like *Gangubai Kathiawadi* and *Queen*. The industry is more open to betting on women-led films because OTT has made it easier for films to succeed outside of the box office.

Q. You have been vocal about your epilepsy. Were you not worried it'd hinder your career?

I came out because I felt comfortable talking about it. I felt that till I normalised epilepsy, others around me would not do so. I wanted to use my platform to make people accept it. Even if I can cause a small dent in the stigma attached to epilepsy, I will be happy.

Q. From *Dangal* to *Sam Bahadur*, what has been your biggest learning?

It's that the industry is very accepting. It's the one place where talent matters and if you have it, you will succeed whatever your caste, colour, creed, social and educational status, whether you know somebody here or not...Your work will decide your success.

with Shashi Sunny